

|1996| THE CHANGING FACE OF PARLIAMENT

The Party Season

Regional aspirations found greater representation in the Lok Sabha

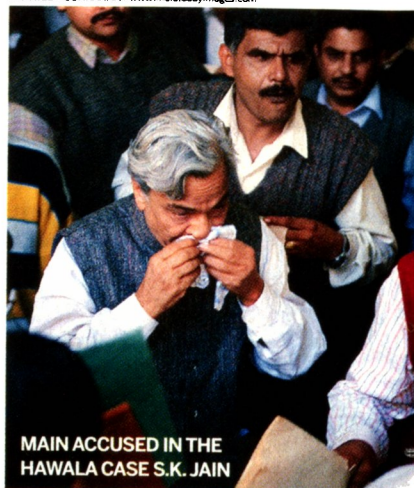
It was the year of the alphabet soup that bewildered the uninitiated and witnessed the arrival of provincial powers to remind us of the limits of bipolarity in Indian politics. The acronyms that represented scores of regional parties—SP, BSP, RJD, BJD, SAD, PMK, JMM, TDP, AGP, RPI and TMC—had come to take the national stage, bringing in regional aspirations, political activity and general thuggery. The elections to the 11th Lok Sabha resulted in a hung Parliament and two years of political instability during which the country would have three prime ministers. While regional politics found articulation through regional parties, the BJP could win only 161 seats and the Congress 140, much below the 271 halfway mark. The growth of regionalism resulted in the presence of 28 parties in the Lok Sabha, unparalleled in Parliament's history. The strength of farmers grew from 33 per cent in the previous House to 52 per cent in the 11th Lok Sabha, giving it a distinct rural tag. "It narrowed the gap between the people and Parliament," said P.A. Sangma, the then Speaker of the Lok Sabha. The fall of the Congress was due to its failure to absorb or put a stop to various local level movements and smaller groups. The regional parties challenged the Congress party's monopoly, by creating a 'clientele' of their own, attracting mostly the backward castes. The number of backward caste MPs rose from 13 per cent in 1971 to 23.3 per cent in 1996. Parliament saw the entry of many regional satraps. Mulayam Singh Yadav, once a small-time wrestler from Saifi village in Uttar Pradesh, became the defence minister of the country, symbolising the seismic change in India's political arena. On June 1, the "humble farmer" from Karnataka, H.D. Deve Gowda, took over the reins of the United Front government as India's 14th prime minister. The 11th Lok Sabha was short, lasting barely two years, but it crystallised the role of not only regional parties as a force multiplier in the matrix of cohabitation politics. In later years, with national parties failing to fire up national imagination, they came in different avatars equipped with an exaggerated sense of indispensability and competitive provincialism.

by Shafi Rahman



THE 11TH LOK SABHA HAD A LARGER PROPORTION OF REGIONAL LEADERS AND FARMERS

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MAIN ACCUSED IN THE HAWALA CASE S.K. JAIN

THE MAIN EVENT

Jain Hawala Scandal

Scandals have rocked this nation before. The Bofors gun deal simmered for some three years before it finally caught fire in 1989, burned a hole into Rajiv Gandhi's reputation as Mr Clean and consumed him and his party. But no scandal has ever created pandemonium sweeping across the entire political establishment as the Jain hawala payoffs have done. Every party appeared shell-shocked and groping for direction when the CBI revealed that it had sought permission to chargesheet three ministers—Balram Jakhar, V.C. Shukla and Madhavrao Scindia—and moved the Supreme Court against Opposition stalwarts like L.K. Advani, Sharad Yadav, Yashwant Sinha and Devi Lal. Advani immediately resigned from Lok Sabha vowing "not to enter Parliament till my name is cleared". *India Today*, Feb. 15, 1996

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THE NUMBER OF BACKWARD CASTE MPs ROSE FROM 13 PER CENT IN 1971 TO 23.3 PER CENT IN 1996.